

1.1 Introduction

For those of us who went over to the OpenOffice camp—partly because of the cost, partly because of the bloat, and partly because of the sense of geeky pride from not succumbing to the “dark side,” MS Office 2007 will be hard to resist—thanks largely to the gorgeous new interface. MS has gone that extra yard to entice people back into its fold by offering a 60-day free trial of the software. A sub-300 MB package containing four constituents of MS Office—Excel, Word, PowerPoint, and OneNote, called MS Office Home and Student 2007, can be downloaded from <http://us7.trymicrosoftoffice.com/default.aspx?culture=en-US> (<http://tinyurl.com/yredyg>) after signing up for a free serial. While one can appreciate the UI immediately after installing, it needs to be activated online before it can be used to create or modify documents. Microsoft also offers an online demo of the new software.

The minimum system requirements for Office 2007 are Windows XP with SP2 (it will not install if SP2 is not detected) or later, a 500 MHz CPU, 256 MB of RAM, a monitor supporting 1024 x 768 resolution, and 1.5 GB of hard disk space. But Microsoft admits that this will not be adequate to use all the features of the package. For example, to be able to use the Grammar and Contextual Spelling features in Word 2007, at least 1 GB of memory is required; the Business Contact Manager feature in Outlook 2007 requires a 1 GHz CPU.

1.2 The Changes

1.2.1 The New User Interface

The MS Office user interface has been revamped, and the change is revolutionary rather than evolutionary. Microsoft describes it as a “results-oriented user interface” and elaborates, in the help file: “Commands and features that were often buried in complex menus and toolbars are now easier to find on task-oriented tabs that contain logical groups of commands and features.” We can’t put it better.